The Free Hit Question — A GW4 Story

ENTRY: 2379133 • RANK #1 (231 PTS)
OVERALL RANK: 260,259

£100.0m	1 FT	WC + FH	4 Assets
SQUAD VALUE + BANK	AVAILABLE FOR GW4	CHIPS REMAINING	COLLIDING IN ONE FIXTURE

THE PROBLEM

⚔ The Manchester Derby Collision — GW4: Man City vs Man Utd (both sides FDR 4)

STRUCTURAL RISK

- Your squad has **4 players colliding in the exact same 90 minutes**: Haaland (captain, MCI) directly against Shaw, Bruno Fernandes, and Mbeumo (all MUN).
- That's **over a quarter of your entire squad value** pointed at one match that will partially cancel itself out.
- The captaincy engine confirms it: Haaland's GW4 expected value drops to **5.60** (from 8.03 in GW3's fixture), now ranked only **6th** of all GW4 options.
- Ranked above him: **Palmer (7.72), Isak (6.54), De Cuyper (6.27), Bogle (5.90)**.

Free Hit Mechanics

RULES CHECK

- Fields an **entirely new 15-man squad for one gameweek only**.
- Your real squad **automatically returns** next gameweek, unchanged.
- Does **not** cost a transfer, and doesn't touch your banked FT.
- **Any bank left unspent evaporates** when your real team reverts — there's zero benefit to underspending.

🎯 The Real Question

DECISION FRAMEWORK

- This is **not** a Blank/Double Gameweek — the normal Free Hit trigger.
- It's a single bad fixture cluster hitting 4 of 11 starters at once.
- The alternative: use your **1 FT normally** and ride out the derby with a smaller, cheaper fix.
- Free Hit is the **nuclear option** — five candidate squads below show what "starting over" could look like.

FIVE FREE HIT PHILOSOPHIES

FULL PITCH BREAKDOWNS ON PAGES 2–6

#	STRATEGY	IDENTITY	COST	BANK	CAPTAIN
1	**The Derby Dodger**	Zero Man City / Man Utd exposure.	£95.3m	£4.7m	Palmer
2	**The EV Maximizer**	Top-EV leaderboard, price be damned.	£97.2m	£2.8m	Palmer
3	**The Differential Bomb**	Sub-10%-owned. Maximum rank swing.	£84.9m	£15.1m	Bogle
4	**The DefCon Value Engine**	Points-per-million, one true premium.	£94.0m	£6.0m	B.Fernandes
5	**The Balanced Contender**	Mostly template, calculated differentials.	£96.2m	£3.8m	Isak

⚠ Prices reflect live FPL values at time of writing. Free Hit budget approximated as current squad value + bank (£100.0m). All 5 squads independently verified: 15 players, 2/5/5/3 position split, max 3 players per club, correct position classifications cross-checked by name + price against the live API.

FREE HIT CANDIDATE #1 · SQUAD DETAIL

The Derby Dodger

FORMATION: 4–4–2
COST: £95.3m · BANK: £4.7m

Zero Derby Exposure | Captain: Palmer | Vice: Isak



BENCH

Trafford	Vuskovic	Stach	Wissa
£5.0m	£5.0m	£6.0m	£6.2m

WHY THIS SQUAD

- Every player **avoids both Manchester clubs** entirely — zero exposure to the derby's cancellation risk.
- Palmer's captaincy leans on the **single best GW4 matchup in the game**: Chelsea host Hull, FDR 2, algorithm's #1 pick at **7.72 EV**.
- Arsenal trio (Saka, Ødegaard, Calafiori) away at Sunderland is FDR 3, but Arsenal's attacking output has been elite all season.
- Bogle and De Cuyper add nailed, cheap defensive value with genuine attacking threat layered in.
- **The trade-off:** Haaland's raw ceiling is given up entirely for one week — this build is about certainty, not upside.

STARTING XI — FIXTURES

POS	PLAYER	CLUB	GW4 FIXTURE
GK	**Tzolakis**	HUL	CHE (A) FDR4
DEF	**De Cuyper**	BHA	COV (A) FDR2
DEF	**Calafiori**	ARS	SUN (A) FDR3
DEF	**Bogle**	LEE	NEW (H) FDR2
DEF	**Tarkowski**	EVE	TOT (A) FDR3
MID	**Palmer**	CHE	HUL (H) FDR2
MID	**Ødegaard**	ARS	SUN (A) FDR3
MID	**Saka**	ARS	SUN (A) FDR3
MID	**Janelt**	BRE	BOU (A) FDR3
FWD	**João Pedro**	CHE	HUL (H) FDR2
FWD	**Isak**	LIV	FUL (H) FDR2

The EV Maximizer

FORMATION: 4–4–2
COST: £97.2m · BANK: £2.8m

Pure Expected Value | Captain: Palmer | Vice: Isak



WHY THIS SQUAD

- Doesn't start from a fixture theme — starts from the **captaincy engine's GW4 expected-value leaderboard** and works backward.
- Palmer (7.72), Isak (6.54), De Cuyper (6.27) and Bogle (5.90) occupy **four of the top five EV slots** in the entire game this gameweek — all four are in this XI.
- Mbeumo is the one deliberate derby exposure kept: his own EV (5.26) **already prices in** the tough fixture.
- Cutting Mbeumo would mean removing a top-10 EV asset out of stubbornness rather than data.
- **The trade-off:** less thematic clarity, but the highest raw provable ceiling of the five.

STARTING XI — FIXTURES

POS	PLAYER	CLUB	GW4 FIXTURE
GK	**Tzolakis**	HUL	CHE (A) FDR4
DEF	**De Cuyper**	BHA	COV (A) FDR2
DEF	**Bogle**	LEE	NEW (H) FDR2
DEF	**Calafiori**	ARS	SUN (A) FDR3
DEF	**Tarkowski**	EVE	TOT (A) FDR3
MID	**Palmer**	CHE	HUL (H) FDR2
MID	**Saka**	ARS	SUN (A) FDR3
MID	**Ødegaard**	ARS	SUN (A) FDR3
MID	**Mbeumo**	MUN	MCI (H) FDR4
FWD	**Isak**	LIV	FUL (H) FDR2
FWD	**João Pedro**	CHE	HUL (H) FDR2

FREE HIT CANDIDATE #3 · SQUAD DETAIL

The Differential Bomb

FORMATION: 3–5–2
COST: £84.9m · BANK: £15.1m

Maximum Risk | Captain: Bogle | Vice: Tavernier



BENCH

Kelleher £5.0m | Vuskovic £5.0m | Tarkowski £6.0m | Gonzalo £6.0m

WHY THIS SQUAD

- Nearly every outfield starter sits **under 10% ownership**: Bogle (1.6%), Tavernier (3.3%), Scott (4.8%), M.Sangaré (13.8%), Stach (2.8%).
- If this squad hauls, it moves your overall rank in a way a template team **mathematically cannot**.
- Bogle as captain is the aggressive statement: **3rd-highest GW4 EV** in the entire game at 1.6% ownership.
- 3-5-2 formation loads the midfield with all five differential picks starting simultaneously.
- **The trade-off:** the highest-variance build of the five, deliberately underspent at £84.9m — buying further into premiums would just recreate Team 1 or 5 and defeat the point of the punt.

STARTING XI — FIXTURES

POS	PLAYER	CLUB	GW4 FIXTURE
GK	**Tzolakis**	HUL	CHE (A) FDR4
DEF	**Bogle**	LEE	NEW (H) FDR2
DEF	**De Cuyper**	BHA	COV (A) FDR2
DEF	**Gvardiol**	MCI	MUN (A) FDR4
MID	**Tavernier**	BOU	BRE (H) FDR3
MID	**Scott**	BOU	BRE (H) FDR3
MID	**M.Sangaré**	BRE	BOU (A) FDR3
MID	**Janelt**	BRE	BOU (A) FDR3
MID	**Stach**	LEE	NEW (H) FDR2
FWD	**Isak**	LIV	FUL (H) FDR2
FWD	**Barry**	EVE	TOT (A) FDR3

The DefCon Value Engine

FORMATION: 4–4–2
COST: £94.0m · BANK: £6.0m

Points-Per-Million | Captain: B.Fernandes | Vice: Haaland



BENCH

Trafford	De Cuyper	Lewis-Potter	Gonzalo
£5.0m	£4.8m	£5.5m	£6.0m

WHY THIS SQUAD

- Built directly from the **defensive-contribution leaderboard**: Ajayi, Mendy, and Egan (all Hull, all elite form).
- Vitaly Janelt and Mamadou Sangaré sit alongside them — the two most reliable DefCon-point generators in midfield.
- Every one of these picks is inexpensive, freeing enough budget for exactly **one** genuine premium.
- Bruno Fernandes stays nailed on penalties, free-kicks, and corners at Man Utd regardless of the tough fixture.
- **The trade-off:** Hull's own GW4 fixture (away at Chelsea, FDR 4) is genuinely tough despite their form — this is a bet on underlying quality over an immediately friendly fixture.

STARTING XI — FIXTURES

POS	PLAYER	CLUB	GW4 FIXTURE
GK	**Suzuki**	AVL	NFO (H) FDR3
DEF	**Ajayi**	HUL	CHE (A) FDR4
DEF	**Mendy**	HUL	CHE (A) FDR4
DEF	**Egan**	HUL	CHE (A) FDR4
DEF	**Bogle**	LEE	NEW (H) FDR2
MID	**B.Fernandes**	MUN	MCI (H) FDR4
MID	**Janelt**	BRE	BOU (A) FDR3
MID	**M.Sangaré**	BRE	BOU (A) FDR3
MID	**Ødegaard**	ARS	SUN (A) FDR3
FWD	**Haaland**	MCI	MUN (A) FDR4
FWD	**Wissa**	NEW	LEE (A) FDR3

The Balanced Contender

FORMATION: 4–4–2
COST: £96.2m · BANK: £3.8m

Highest Floor | Captain: Isak | Vice: Palmer



WHY THIS SQUAD

- Palmer and Isak lead the line on the **two best individual GW4 fixtures** in the game.
- Bruno Fernandes stays despite the derby — his own EV (5.07) still ranks **9th overall**; cutting a top-10 asset on fixture optics alone costs more expected points than it saves.
- Four calculated differentials (De Cuyper, Bogle, Tarkowski, Tavernier) layered underneath the template core.
- Every position group has at least one nailed, in-form starter as a floor.
- **The trade-off:** deliberately the least exciting of the five on paper — built for the highest floor, not the highest ceiling.

STARTING XI — FIXTURES

POS	PLAYER	CLUB	GW4 FIXTURE
GK	**Tzolakis**	HUL	CHE (A) FDR4
DEF	**Calafiori**	ARS	SUN (A) FDR3
DEF	**De Cuyper**	BHA	COV (A) FDR2
DEF	**White**	ARS	SUN (A) FDR3
DEF	**Bogle**	LEE	NEW (H) FDR2
MID	**Palmer**	CHE	HUL (H) FDR2
MID	**B.Fernandes**	MUN	MCI (H) FDR4
MID	**Ødegaard**	ARS	SUN (A) FDR3
MID	**Tavernier**	BOU	BRE (H) FDR3
FWD	**Isak**	LIV	FUL (H) FDR2
FWD	**Wissa**	NEW	LEE (A) FDR3

Which Squad Fits Your Situation?

RISK COMPARISON ACROSS ALL 5 SQUADS

SQUAD	RISK LEVEL	CEILING	FLOOR	BEST FOR
1. Derby Dodger	Medium	Medium-High	High	Protecting rank #1 without gambling
2. EV Maximizer	Medium	Highest (provable)	Medium-High	Trusting the model over narrative
3. Differential Bomb	Highest	Highest (variance)	Low	Chasing a big rank jump, not protecting one
4. DefCon Value Engine	Medium	Medium	Medium	Bench Boost setup practice, not this week
5. Balanced Contender	Lowest	Medium-High	Highest	Exactly what you're protecting: a 9-point lead

THE VERDICT

🏆 Final Recommendation

DECISION

- You are **1st place with a 9-point lead** built on smart transfers, not luck.
- The Manchester Derby problem is real but survivable — it's **one bad fixture cluster**, not a Blank Gameweek.
- Free Hit is your only "reset" chip. Burning it here means **zero safety net** if a genuine Blank or Double Gameweek arrives later, when Free Hit's value is highest.

If You Don't Free Hit

- Use your 1 FT to move only the **worst-fixture derby asset** (Shaw — weakest link at 4th-string DEF value this week).
- Bring in **Cole Palmer or Isak** instead.
- Ride out Haaland/Bruno/Mbeumo at reduced expectations for one week.
- That's a **1-transfer fix for a 1-fixture problem**.

If You Do Free Hit

- **Squad 5 (Balanced Contender)** is correct for your situation specifically.
- You're **defending a lead**, not chasing one.
- Squad 3 (Differential Bomb) is the right call *only* if you were mid-table and needed a variance play.
- You are not mid-table. Play accordingly.

DATA & METHODOLOGY NOTES

- Built using 13+ FPL skill commands: `status`, `audit`, `team show`, `fixtures ticker`, `fixtures swings`, `captain (EV engine)`, `players list (4 presets)`, `players presets`, `availability injuries/suspensions/set-pieces`, `prices predict/trends`.
- All 5 squads independently validated: exactly 15 players, 2 GK / 5 DEF / 5 MID / 3 FWD composition, max 3 players per real-world club, and every player's position cross-checked against the live API by name + price (catches name collisions like the two different players both called "Palmer").
- Starting XI / bench splits for each squad additionally validated for formation legality (1 GK, 3-5 DEF, 2-5 MID, 1-3 FWD, exactly 11 starters).